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# Waiting for a repair

## Shared facilities in Sydney apartment housing

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A3. Context exploration and mapping | IDEA9106 Design Thinking | Semester 2, 2026

Wenxi Ma | wema0811 | Tutorial 23



### Introduction

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Waiting is scheduled and staffed but rarely well designed. Maister (1985) argued that uncertain, unexplained and unfair waits feel longest; Larson (1987) added that people judge and perceive a queue by whether its order seems proper, which assumes that the queue can be seen.

The consequences are uneven. When the only lift in an apartment building in Melbourne failed overnight, a wheelchair user found no notice and no explanation: told a repair had been logged, he heard nothing further, paid for a hotel, and was shut inside his unit the next day when work resumed (Coghill, 2025). In social housing in Sydney, a tenant waited nine days for hot water against a 24-hour target; an 83-year-old's 13-day outage was fixed within two hours once a minister's office intervened (Gerathy, 2024). What separates a nine-day wait from a two-hour one is often not capacity but who is able to ask, and be answered.

I chose shared-facility repairs because a renter can report a problem but has no say in what happens next. The landlord, the building manager and the contractor decide the order of the work. The law is no help either: it says these things have to be repaired, but it never says by when (*Strata Schemes Management Act 2015* (NSW), s 106(1); *Residential Tenancies Act 2010* (NSW), s 63). Capacity is fixed. My question is not how to make repairs faster, but what the wait is like for the people inside it: what they are told, what they infer when told nothing, and what they do while they wait.

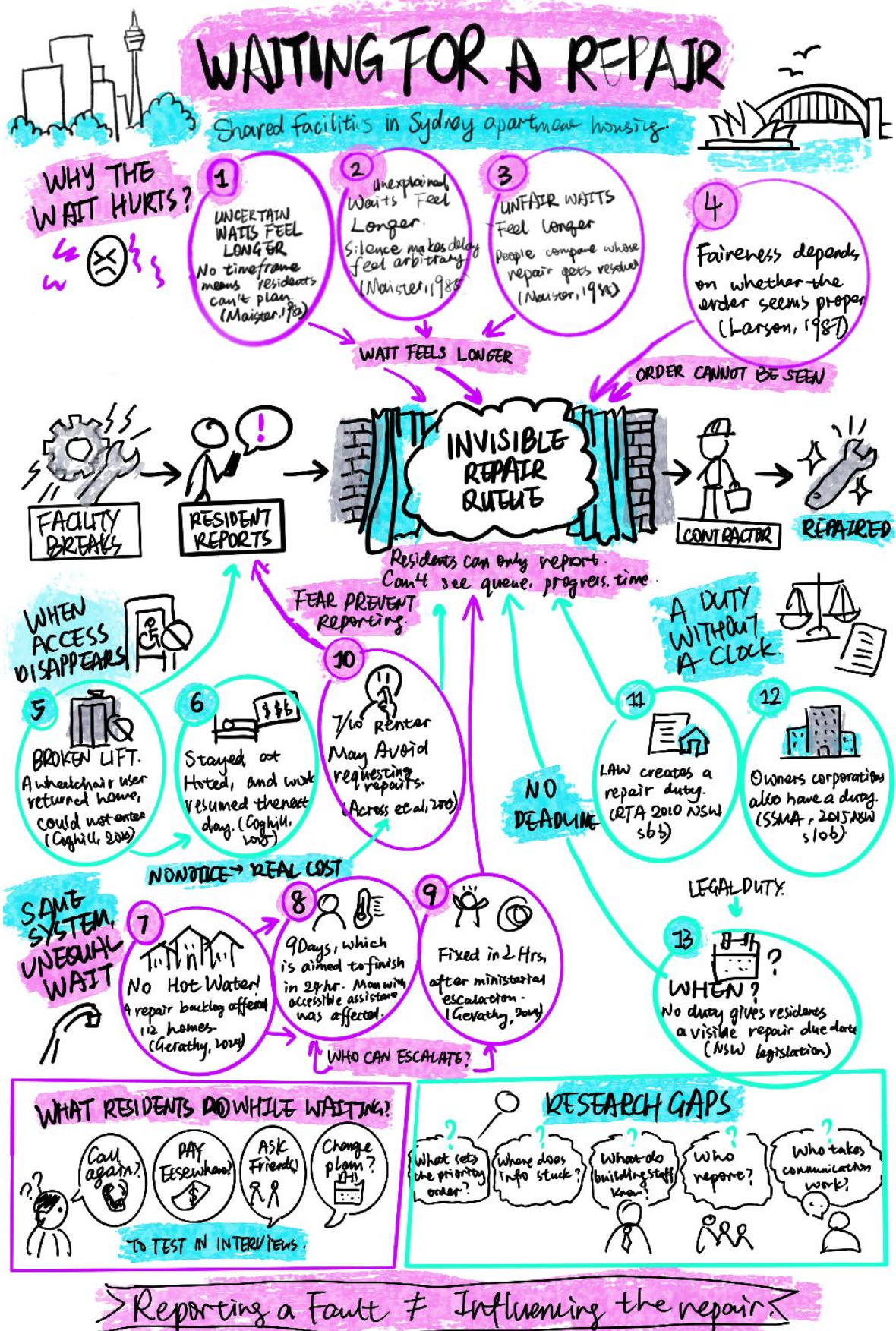


Figure 1. Sketchnote of thirteen secondary research findings.

## Project area

When a shared facility breaks, residents can report it but rarely learn what happens next: when the repair will occur, how urgent it is considered, or whether another job has been prioritised. I want to understand how information moves during a repair, who can ask questions, and what residents do meanwhile.

My mapping shows why: the people who live with the fault sit furthest from the decision, and reporting is not the same as influencing. The project area is therefore the information that moves, or fails to move, between a resident and the people who sequence the work.

Capacity is fixed, so I am not proposing to make repairs faster. The solution space I want to investigate is anything that makes the wait legible from inside it: a status a reported fault carries, an expected timeframe given when it is reported, or a way to see where a job sits relative to others.

## Stakeholder map

A repair passes through a chain of people who each hold part of the information, and residents rarely see past the first link. Mapping the chain shows where information stops, and lets me narrow to the stakeholders my interviews should target.

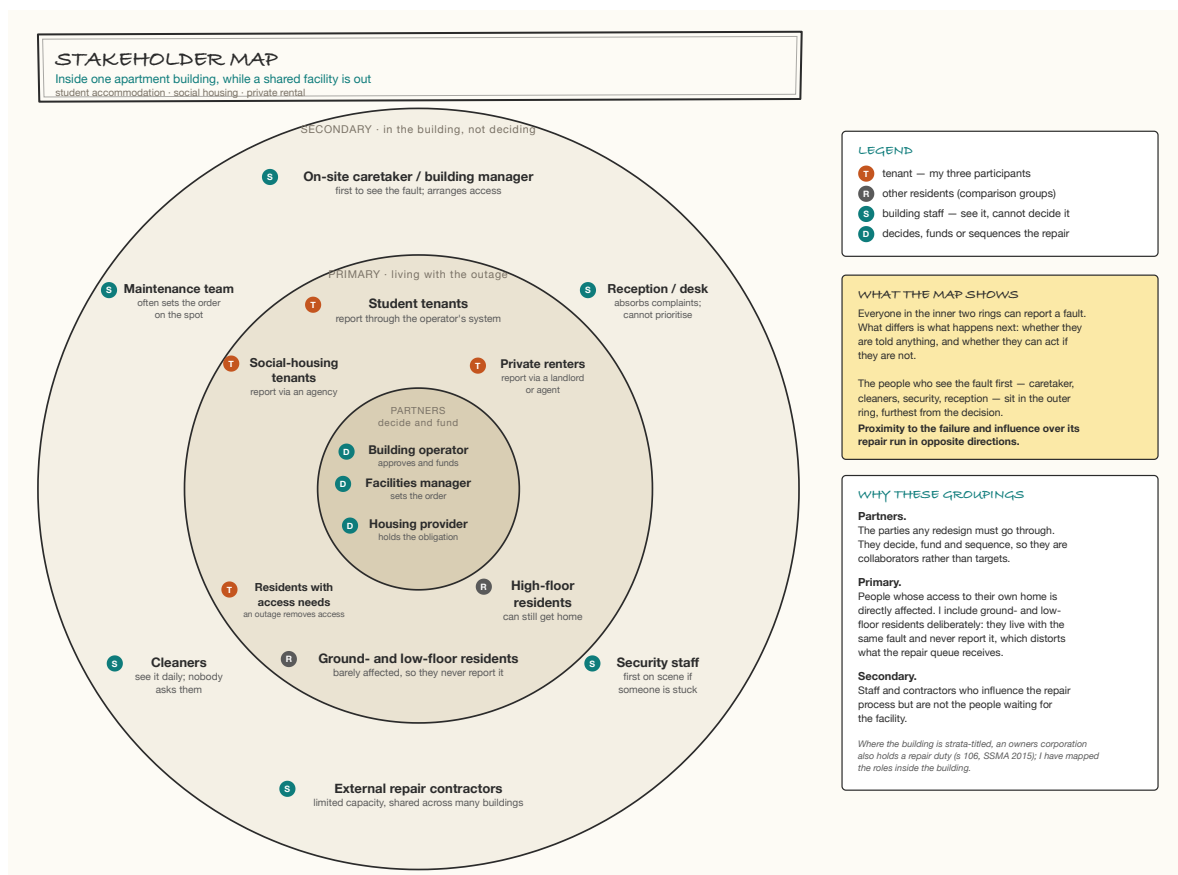


Figure 2. Stakeholder map.

I grouped stakeholders by position relative to the failure, not by organisation. Partners decide, fund and sequence the work, so any redesign passes through them. Primary stakeholders are those whose access to their home is affected; I include ground-floor residents deliberately, because they live with the same fault and never report it, which distorts what the queue receives. Secondary stakeholders see the fault first but sit furthest from the decision.

## Power map

The stakeholder map shows who is involved; it does not show who can act. The power map separates the two, because that gap is where this project sits.

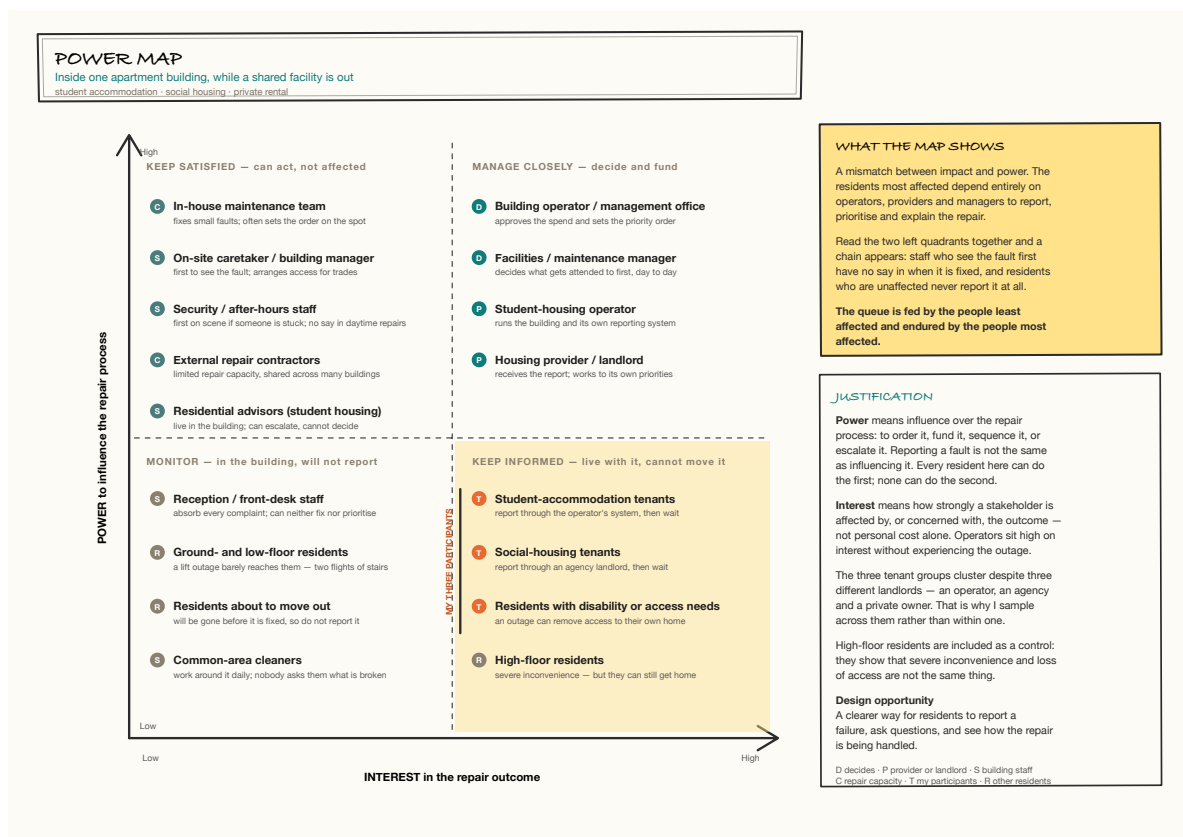


Figure 3. Power map.

Power means influence over the repair: to order, fund, sequence or escalate it. Reporting is not influencing, and every resident group here can do the first but not the second. Interest means how strongly a stakeholder is affected, which is why operators sit high on interest without experiencing the outage. High-floor residents are a comparison case: inconvenience and loss of access are not the same thing.

## Research plan

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### 1. Target users / stakeholders

My target group is residents who live with a shared-facility failure but have no influence over when it is repaired. I will sample three variants: a student-accommodation tenant, a social-housing tenant, and a resident with disability or access needs, for whom an outage removes access rather than delaying it. The landlord changes, while the resident's position does not, so a shared finding is structural rather than one provider's failure.

### 2. Recruitment and sampling strategy

I will use purposive sampling to select three participants with different living situations (Patton, 2015). All must have experienced a shared-facility breakdown in their building within the past twelve months. I will recruit through university networks, a personal contact, and disability and student-support networks, without identifying anyone by impairment. Comparing these different cases may reveal common patterns (Palinkas et al., 2015).

### 3. Ethical considerations

As the participants are tenants, the main risk is possible consequences for their tenancy. A social-housing tenant may be identifiable through building or agency details, so I will not record personal information and will label transcripts as Participant 1–3. I will also avoid reducing participants with access needs to their impairment by asking about specific experiences rather than diagnoses or medical history. Before recording, I will obtain written consent covering the study's purpose, recording, anonymisation, coursework-only use and the right to withdraw. A completed risk assessment identifies a further risk: participants may raise unresolved housing problems. I will not offer legal or housing advice, and will provide Tenants' Union of NSW contact details if asked.

### 4. Draft interview questions

The same five questions are asked in the same wording to all three participants; holding them constant makes the accounts comparable.

1. Tell me about the last time something shared in your building broke — a lift, a door, the hot water. Walk me through what happened.
2. Who did you tell, and what happened after that?
3. Talk me through what you were told about how long it would be out for — and what you did with that information.
4. What did you end up doing while it was broken?
5. How did you work out whether that wait was reasonable or not?

**Follow-up probes** Housing-specific differences are handled here rather than by changing the questions.

- *Student accommodation:* Was there a system you were meant to use — a portal, an app, a front desk? Did other residents know about it too?
- *Social housing:* Did you know who was responsible for fixing it? Had you reported something before? What happened that time?
- *Access needs:* Was that before or after you were already downstairs? Has it changed how you plan things since?

## Questions remaining after my initial research

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1. What determines the order of repair jobs? The weighting is invisible from outside.
2. Where does information stop — is it never produced, or produced and not passed on? Each points to a different design response.
3. How much do building staff already know that residents do not?
4. Do unaffected residents really not report faults?
5. Who absorbs the extra communication work, given fixed capacity?

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*Strata Schemes Management Act 2015* (NSW). <https://legislation.nsw.gov.au/view/html/inforce/current/act-2015-050>

## Appendix A — Interview transcripts

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Participant 1: Opening: Thank you for taking part. This interview is about your experience when a shared facility in your building broke down. It will take about 3–5 minutes. With your signed consent, I will audio-record it. You may skip any question or stop at any time. Is it okay to begin?

A: Yeah, that's fine. We can start.

Q: Tell me about the last time something shared in your building broke — a lift, a door, or the hot water. Walk me through what happened.

A: The Wi-Fi box in my room started making this really high buzzing sound. I first noticed it one night while I was studying. Honestly, I thought it would just stop by itself, so I waited for about a week. But it didn't stop, and actually it felt much louder at night. After that, it started affecting my sleep and study.

Q: Who did you tell, and what happened after that?

A: I reported it through the apartment's online maintenance system. I explained what the noise sounded like and where it came from. A few days later, nothing had happened, so I went to the front desk. The staff said they would pass it on, but honestly, nobody contacted me or came to check it. It just felt like my report disappeared.

Q: Did anyone contact you and discuss when this issue would be fixed?

A: No, nobody gave me a date or even an estimated time. Actually, they told me it was my own problem and I should deal with it myself. I kept checking the system for a while, but there were no updates. And then I realised they probably weren't going to do anything, so I stopped checking.

Q: What did you end up doing while it wasn't working?

A: Honestly, I just learned to live with the noise. I moved my desk, put a folded towel under the box, and wore earphones while studying. At night, I sometimes played music to cover the sound. None of these things actually fixed it, but they helped a little. I was busy with classes and assignments, so I eventually stopped asking.

Q: Did you change your daily routine? Did you avoid going out or coming back at certain times?

A: A little. I started studying outside my room more often, like in the library. I also sometimes stayed out later because the noise was more obvious when my room was quiet.

Q: How did you work out whether that wait was reasonable or not?

A: Honestly, I didn't think it was reasonable at all. The box belonged to the building, so I didn't think I should have to fix it myself. Also, they never gave me an update or a clear answer. I didn't stop asking because the problem was solved. I stopped because, like, I felt they weren't going to help.

Q: Is there anything else about repairs or waiting in your building that you think is important? Thank you for your time.

A: Maybe just one thing. I think small problems are often ignored because they don't affect everyone. But actually, this noise affected my sleep and study every day. And honestly, many students probably stop complaining because they know they'll move out soon.

Participant 2: Q: Could you Tell me about the last time something shared in your building went bad

or broke — a lift, a door, the hot water. You can Walk me through what happened

A: The carpet in my flat and in the corridor started to smell of mould. It happened after the building manager cleaned the carpets. The water was never dried properly, so the carpet stayed wet for a long time. After that there was a strong mould smell everywhere. It was in my room and it was in the corridor too, so I could smell it as soon as I step into the bulding.

Q: That's really bad and affects everyday life. So Who did you tell, and what happened after that?

A: I told the building manager many times. He sent several different people to come and look at it. Some of them said 'I cannot smell anything.' Others said 'We can clean the carpet again for you.' But the cleaning was the cause of the problem in the first place, so cleaning it again would not help. Every visit ended in the same place, and nothing really changed.

Q: Did anyone gave you information about the exact date that it would be fixed?.

A: Nobody ever gave me a date, because nobody agreed there was a problem. The hard part is that we had no equipment to measure it, and there is no fixed standard for a smell. If they say they cannot smell it, I cannot prove anything. So it was not really about waiting for a repair. It was about waiting for someone to accept that the problem was real.

Q: What did you end up doing while it smells bad and feels like unhealthy?

A: I opened the windows all the time and kept the door of my room closed. I tried to stay out of the apartment more. In the end nothing was done. The problem was only solved when I moved out and stopped living there. I lived with the smell for the whole time I was in that building.

Q: Did you change how you used your room? Did it affect your health or sleep?

A: Yes, I did many times of cleaning. I bought a kind of carpet wash powder from supermarket, and vacuum after using it as recommendation from online platform. I turned the fan and window on everyday, that actually affects my sleep a lot.

Q: How did you work out whether that wait was reasonable or not?

A: I do not think it was reasonable. The real reason for the delay was cost. Replacing the carpet is expensive, so the manager did not want to take that responsibility. Offering to clean it again was cheap and it looked like an action, but it was not a solution. What made the waiting so painful was that there was no clear standard and no end point, so I never knew if anything would ever happen.

Q: Is there anything else about repairs or waiting in your building that you think is important?

A: Yes, one thing. When a problem has no number and no machine to measure it, the resident always loses. If a lift is broken, everyone can see it. A smell is different — they can just say they cannot smell it, and that ends the conversation. I think there should be an agreed way to check these things, done by someone who is not the person paying for the repair.

Participant 3:

Opening: Thank you for taking part. This interview is about your experience when a shared facility in your building broke down and will take 3–5 minutes. With your signed consent, I will audio-record it. You may skip any question or stop at any time. Is it okay to begin?

Q: Tell me about the last time something shared in your building broke, a lift, a door, the hot water. Walk me through what happened.

A: I live in a student apartment, and the lift here stops working quite often. That time I came back

from outside and found it was broken again. I was carrying heavy bags, and my foot was injured at that time, so the lift was the only way I could get up to my room. I stood in the lobby and did not know what to do.

Q: Who did you tell, and what happened after that? A: I could not tell anyone at that moment, because the front desk staff had already finished work. So I called a friend who lives in the same building. She came down, helped me carry my things, and we went up through the fire escape stairs together. She supported me the whole way. After I got back to my room, I submitted a maintenance request on the apartment website.

Q: Talk me through what you were told about how long it would be out for, and what you did with that information. A: I was told 'we are waiting for the engineer', which is not a time. What I needed to know was whether it would be one hour or one day, because those are two completely different decisions for me, either I wait downstairs, or I arrange to stay somewhere else. Without that, I could not decide anything.

Q: What did you end up doing while it was broken? A: I kept calling the front desk to ask about it. I also asked my friend to bring food back for me, so my life became a little easier. I went out much less than before, because going out meant using the stairs again. In the end nobody told me when the lift was fixed. One day I left my room and just saw that it was working again.

Q: How did you work out whether that wait was reasonable or not? A: I do not think it was reasonable. I did not know when they started the repair, and I did not know when it would be finished. Everything was unknown, so I could not even judge whether the wait was fair or not. And this kind of thing happens a lot here. Sometimes it is the lift, sometimes the toilet does not flush. It is not one accident, it keeps repeating. These problems have also changed how I plan my day. For example, I worry that the water will be cut off, so I wash and brush my teeth very early, because I do not want to face a night with no water at all. It really affects my normal life.

## Appendix B — Signed consent forms

Three scanned consent forms, signed before recording began.

### Usability Testing

### Data sheet (3)

#### Consent Form

I agree to participate in the study conducted and recorded by Wenxi Ma.

I agree to:

- ☒ The session being audio/video-recorded (cross out as appropriate)
- ☒ The use of photographs and video recordings for the purpose of documenting the findings from this study

I understand that the information collected in this study is for research purposes only and that my name and image will not be used for any other purpose. I relinquish any rights to the recording.

I understand that participation in this usability study is voluntary, and I agree to immediately raise any concerns or areas of discomfort during the session with the study administrator.

I confirm that I have read and understand the information on this form and that any questions I might have about the session have been answered.

Date: 2026.8.28

Please print your name: Anda Hao

Please sign your name: Anda Hao

Thank you! We appreciate your participation.

### Consent Form

I agree to participate in the study conducted and recorded by Wenxi Ma.

I agree to:

- ☒ The session being audio/video-recorded (cross out as appropriate)
- ☒ The use of photographs and video recordings for the purpose of documenting the findings from this study

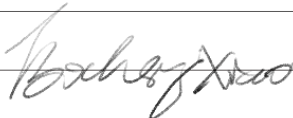
I understand that the information collected in this study is for research purposes only and that my name and image will not be used for any other purpose. I relinquish any rights to the recording.

I understand that participation in this usability study is voluntary, and I agree to immediately raise any concerns or areas of discomfort during the session with the study administrator.

I confirm that I have read and understand the information on this form and that any questions I might have about the session have been answered.

Date: 2026.8.28

Please print your name: Bocheng Xiao

Please sign your name: 

Thank you! We appreciate your participation.

### Consent Form

I agree to participate in the study conducted and recorded by Wenxi Ma.

I agree to:

- ☒ The session being audio/video-recorded (cross out as appropriate)
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I confirm that I have read and understand the information on this form and that any questions I might have about the session have been answered.

Date: 2026.8.28

Zeyu Li

Please print your name: \_\_\_\_\_

Please sign your name: Zeyu Li

Thank you! We appreciate your participation.

## Appendix C — Acknowledgement of templates

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The sketchnote, stakeholder map and power map in this report were inspired by template from unit resources, slightly modified on color and style.

## AI Appendix

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Generative AI (Claude) was used in the preparation of this assignment in the following ways.

I used it to help locate legal sources, specifically the provisions of the *Strata Schemes Management Act 2015* (NSW) and the *Residential Tenancies Act 2010* (NSW) cited in this report. I checked each section against the legislation before including it.

I used it to help with structure and lay out the sketchnote with working from findings and framings I identified myself.

I used it to refine the wording of the written sections for concision, in order to meet the word limits.

I use it to generate overleaf template of my report to contain all the content that I have.